



A System so *Fucked* up, it's perfect.



AN AUTOETHNOGRAPHIC ZINE
ON THE SOUTH ASIAN DIASPORA

pov: you denied Sharmaji's
daughter's biodata without
asking your father, no more
free Haldiram's bhujia for you
from the Sharmajis.





Hamesha mere haath mei dard ho ta tha, mere dimag se pehle

I grew up hearing my mom tell her fellow brown, Tory Burch-sandal-wearing, Instagram-reel-sending, designer handbag-obsessed aunties that I had a desire to play the tabla since I was a toddler. Legend (my father) says that I couldn't begin earlier because my fingers were too small. I started learning in the BAPS temple at five-and-a-half years old instead of on my fifth birthday. Had I started learning half a year before, perhaps I could have performed at Carnegie Hall.

Conveniently, the BAPS temple was being built just a few miles from my home, and classes were just \$25 for 45 minutes. Apparently the Koreans in Princeton were paying \$100 an hour for violin classes.

Aashirvad and Chai

Group classes from BAPS eventually became private lessons in the discomfort of our home's media/TV/exercise room. The ritual was the same every Thursday at 5 pm. Uncle would come straight from work with his Costco-bought, Ted Baker button-down on, from where I had to touch his feet as soon as he entered our home. His beer— or Jack Daniels belly, or whatever-he-drank-when-he-bitched-about-his-wife belly — would keep him from sitting down on the ground directly.

My mom would instruct me ten minutes before every class that I must ask if Uncle wanted chai. The chai was already made five minutes before each lesson regardless. Full tray, Marie Gold biscuits, and the occasional home-cooked pakoda when it was rainy outside. She would say hi, crack an appropriate joke about the weather, then disappear into the kitchen.

For only \$10 extra per week, I learned how to fight with Indian adults to ensure I bring their plates to the kitchen instead. Private lessons were worth it turns out.



Te Re Ke Te Ta Ka Ta Ka

Growing up through elementary and middle school, I learned that I should practice each particular bol 100 times per day if I wanted to perfect it. If I perfected it, I could perform at the next Diwali function in Edison. At that function is going to be Vijaya Auntie whose daughter is an Ivy League-educated physician who will be so impressed at little, cheeky Atishay playing tabla and will potentially give him shadowing opportunities down the line. Shadowing opportunities and clout from Indian aunties?! Performing was a no-brainer for me.

With time, I began to genuinely enjoy the taals I was learning. I still remember the day I could finally play tabla alongside my favorite Bollywood song at age 10. Salman Khan's performance in *Tere Mast Mast Do Nain* was who I aspired to be back then: a ripped, Bollywood-actor who got all the women. How I would get there was almost entirely determined by agreeing to perform in front of random crowds of drunk Indians at an educational gala fundraiser (most likely a tax-front), and then for those same Indians the next morning at the mandir.



Acne

Once my parents deemed me worthy enough to stop private classes, Uncle had bought a Tesla, left his affiliation with BAPS tabla classes, and moved into a nicer, spacier home in the meanwhile. That meant I could go back to group classes.

Here, I saw acne on brown kids for the first time.

I learned that there were a bunch of kids in the surrounding towns that learned from Uncle. The foyer had fifteen pairs of shoes and the living room had several other kids sitting cross-legged on the floor with their own tablas. There was even a girl. I had never known girls even played tabla. I had never known that kids other than me could play tabla better, faster even. Apparently Uncle even had a business called “Rhthym Academy” that ran entirely on WhatsApp (turns out the Tesla-federal-tax-rebate papers did not have the word Rhythm spelled correctly). Uncle cracked the same jokes and sang the same songs.

By this point, I had stopped touching his feet too.



Zakir

Scene: McCarter Theater, Princeton, NJ. It's 6:30 pm, the concert starts at 9 pm, but of course I am already there. I'd idolized Zakir as a kid as someone who was the epitome in something unconventional. I filled up whatever storage I had left in my iPhone 6 recording voice memos of Zakir and Béla jamming. Whispering to my mom to be quiet at the start and end of each recording, I was adamant to capture all of it.

I went to school the next morning and told Dr. MacDonald about the concert. She then gave me some musical recommendations, which I never ended up listening to. In the coming years, I picked up the one English song I actually knew the lyrics to (shout-out to Bruno Mars's "Uptown Funk"), went around telling people that I was so inspired by Zakir that I started to play fusion tabla, and eventually found myself four years later, playing tabla on a really shitty cover of "Uptown Funk" alongside the high school jazz band. A majority of the rehearsals were spent arguing with the band director to increase my microphone volume against the drum kit. How could the high school say no to an ethnic instrument in a jazz band? If not Carnegie, maybe McCarter would suffice.

Hard Techno

Art can exist to not perform, turns out.

Last month, I pulled my tabla out from under my bed. It was dusty. A buddy of mine was at my place, an incredible artist, playing some track that blended classical with EDM. I tried to play along.

I couldn't lock in. I was half a step behind the tempo every time. I tried again. Again. He watched me for a minute and told me to find my groove.

He meant it simply. He's like that.



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I DIDN'T GET MEDITATIVE. I COULDN'T DO IT.
SORRY MOM.



AJ

